

EXCLUSIVE

IAS PRELIMS 2026

CURRENT AFFAIRS

REVISION

GS-1 (DYNAMIC)

MODULE - 53



**MISCELLANEOUS
EVENTS - 7**



AYATOLLAH MOJTABA KHAMENEI ... THE NEW SUPREME LEADER OF IRAN

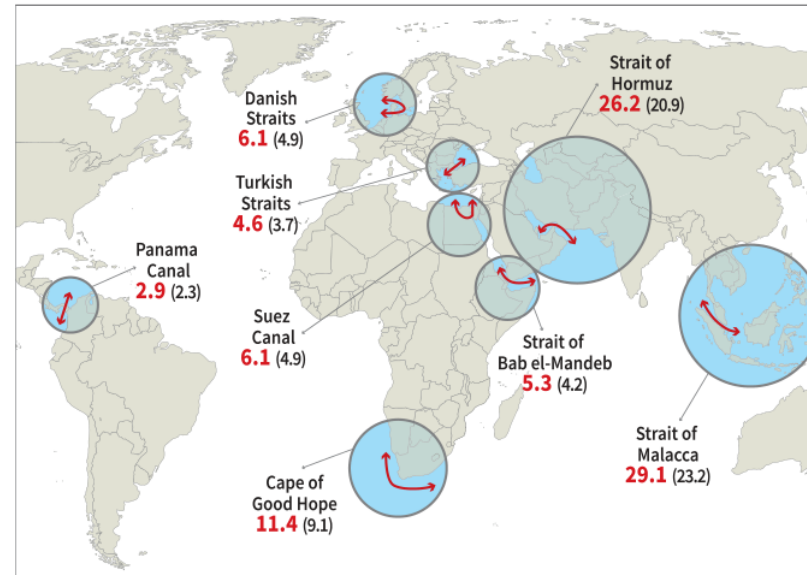
- Iran's Assembly of Experts, the 88-member clerical body, chose the 57-year-old Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei as the Supreme Leader. His father was assassinated in a joint US-Israeli strike on February 28.
- Several family members of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was assassinated on February 28, were also killed.
- Mojtaba Khamenei has maintained close ties with the Islamic Revolutionary God Corps (IRGC), and the clerical establishment.
- By elevating him, Tehran has sent an unmistakable message - the Islamic Republic stands firm despite the war.





Strait of Malacca followed by Strait of Hormuz form the most critical choke points in global maritime energy trade

Share of global trade in % (trade in million barrels/day) as of first half of 2025



West Asian countries collectively have the largest oil reserves, leading to conflicts for the ownership of the precious resource

Venezuela	3,03,221	UAE	1,13,000	Nigeria	37,280	Algeria	12,200
Saudi Arabia	2,67,200	Kuwait	1,01,500	Kazakhstan	30,000	Ecuador	8,273
Iran	2,08,600	Russia	80,000	China	28,182	Azerbaijan	7,000
Canada	1,63,000	Libya	48,363	Qatar	25,244	Norway	6,912
Iraq	1,45,019	US	45,014	Brazil	15,894	India	4,981

Proven petroleum reserves in the world 2024 (billion barrels)

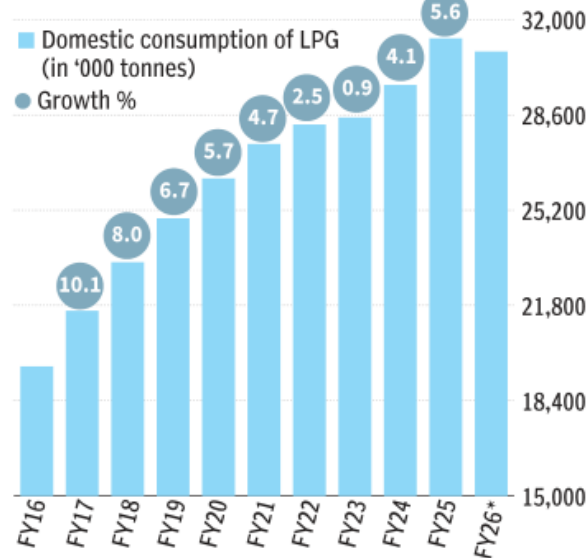
• Thechokepoint



- Strait of Hormuz, overall, accounts for about 20% of global crude oil supplies. Nearly, half of India's crude oil imports of five million barrels per day comes from Gulf region through Strait of Hormuz. India's import dependence of crude oil is around 88%.
- At the same time, half of India's LNG requirement and about 62% of its LPG requirement are met through imports.
- Three countries, Qatar, Oman and UAE account for 68% of India's LNG imports. Over 90% of LPG imports of \$13.9 billion in 2025 were from West Asia.
- If the war prolongs, India may be hit by both price and quantity shocks. Price may be affected on account of rising market price as well as a depreciating currency.

With gradual increase in the domestic consumption of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), import dependence is also growing. While about 46 per cent of domestic demand was met by imports in FY16, this has gone up to 61 per cent in FY26. This import dependence raises strategic vulnerabilities in India's energy security, especially in cases like the present West Asia conflict, as India sources 80-90 per cent of its LPG imports from that region

Domestic consumption of LPG increasing at a slow pace



But share of domestic LPG consumption being met by imports is on the rise

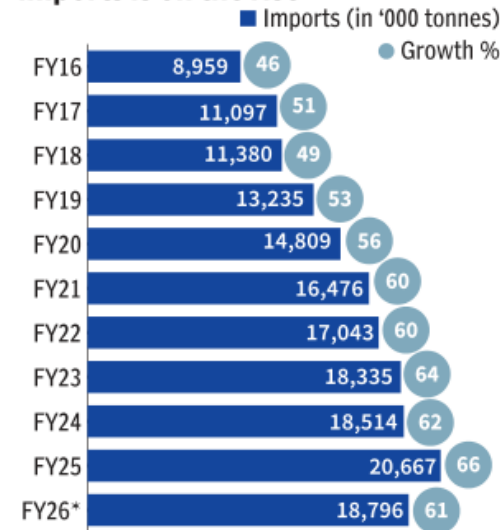


CHART 1: Number of active domestic LPG consumers in India (in lakhs)

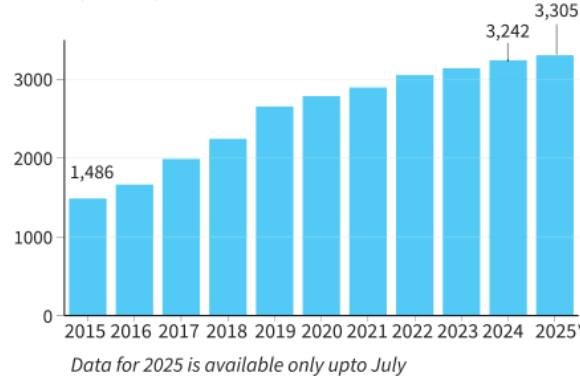


CHART 4: The total import of liquified natural gas (in million metric tonnes)

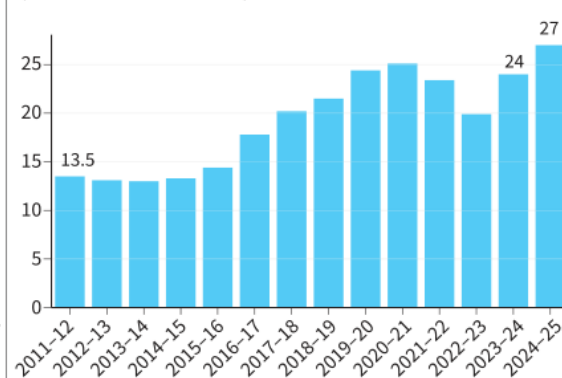


CHART 2: The total import of liquified petroleum gas (in million metric tonnes)

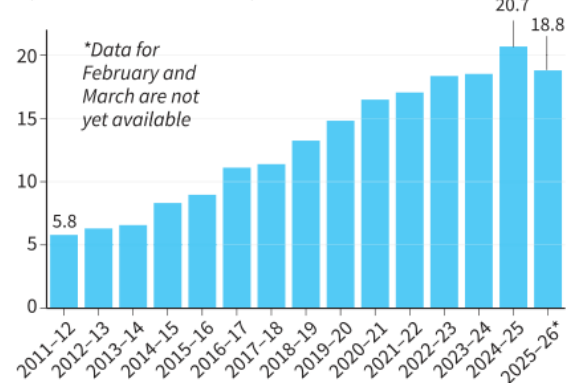
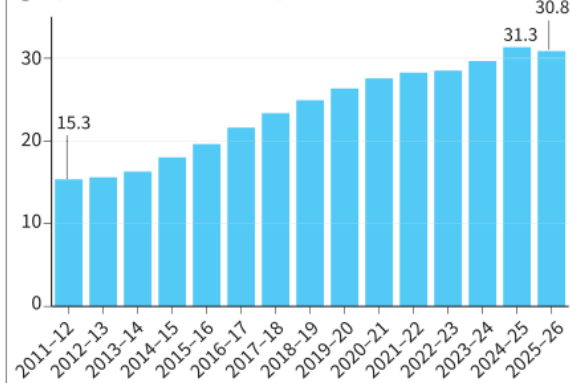


CHART 5: The domestic consumption of liquefied petroleum gas (in million metric tonnes)



GOVERNMENT INVOKED ESSENTIAL COMMODITIES ACT, 1955



- Government invoked the Essential Commodities Act, 1955. The concerned ministry has sought diverting natural gas to certain priority sectors with a tiered structure.
- The Ministry underlined domestic Piped Natural Gas (PNG), Compressed Natural Gas (CNG) for vehicular fuel and Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) production alongside fertilizer manufacturing, tea industries, manufacturing and other industrial consumers among the priority sectors.



- The US treasury issued an order that would allow India to import Russian oil for 30 days. Analysts say that this will help mitigate the spike in the price of oil and delays in oil shipments to import-dependent India.
- As per USA, it was granting India this reprieve to “alleviate pressure caused by Iran's attempt to take global energy hostage”. This deliberately short-term measure will not provide significant financial benefit to the Russian government, as it only authorizes transactions involving oil already stranded at sea, as per USA.
- However, government sources confirmed that Russian oil may no longer come at a discount and that China was also competing for it.



KILLING OF HIGH-PROFILE OFFICIALS & WEAPONIZATION OF THE GLOBAL ENERGY SYSTEMS

- Israel killed Ali Larijani, Iran's Security Chief and one of the most prominent remaining figures in the regime. Soleimani, the head of the paramilitary Basij Force, died on the same day.
- Iran's Intelligence Minister was killed in a separate strike.
- Iran's South Pars Gas Field was struck by Israel. In retaliation, Iran hit Qatar's Ras Laffan LNG hub. Ras Laffan underpins roughly a fifth of global LNG supply.
- South Pars is the world's largest gas field, jointly shared by Iran and Qatar.
- Experts say that it is weaponization of the global energy systems.

SHAHED-136 UNMANNED AERIAL VEHICLES IN THE NEWS



- Shahed-136 Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs) are of Iranian make. Each one of them carry a 25 kg warhead and costs less than \$30,000 to make.
- Effective interceptors such as the patriot can cost millions. This imbalance means that war is now easier to fight on the offensive and that even less advanced nations can pack a potent counter punch.
- Iran, long subjected to isolation and sanctions, has been able to build thousands of Shaheds. They also sold a number of Shaheds to Russia over the years.
- In the recent military exchange with Pakistan, at one point, Pakistan used over 600 UAVs simultaneously into the Indian airspace.

There is a clear opportunity for the indigenous defence industry as well as for startups to focus their attention on developing cheaper systems.

TERMINAL HIGH ALTITUDE AREA DEFENSE (THAAD) IS IN THE NEWS



- Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) is one of the most advanced missile defence platforms developed by the USA to counter ballistic missile threats. It can destroy incoming threats both inside and outside Earth's atmosphere. It provides a critical defensive layer against short, medium and limited intermediate range ballistic missiles.
- It destroys incoming targets by directly colliding with them at extremely high speeds, relying on kinetic energy rather than an explosive blast. This approach significantly improves precision and reduces the risk of debris from explosive interceptors affecting populated areas.
- THAAD weapon system is a major element of the broader Ballistic Missile Defense System (BMDS) architecture. It is highly mobile and rapidly deployable.



- A damaged reactor core or spent fuel pool could release Cesium-137, a long-lived isotope that causes acute radiation sickness and contaminates land for decades.
- Radioactive particles can be carried by winds affecting global food security.
- Damaging nuclear facilities overseen by an unstable regime also risks loss of custody of enriched Uranium.



Risky voyage

LPG carrier *Shivalik* reportedly left Qatar on March 7

Shivalik's cargo carrying capacity is equal to one day of India's LPG imports

Vessel position at 10:30 pm Indian time March 13



Source: marinetraffic.com

US installations damaged in strikes

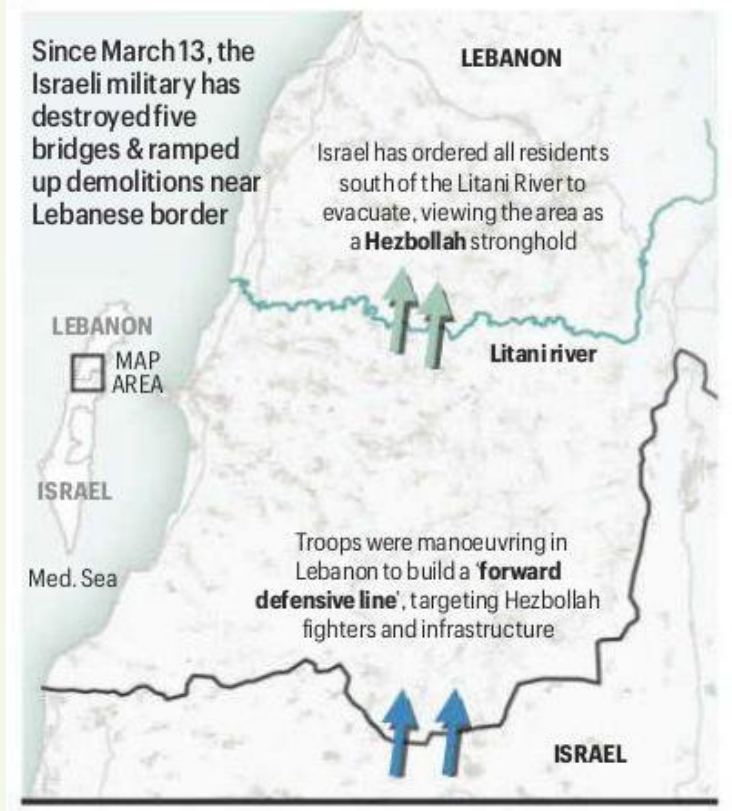


● US base or a base hosting US forces ● Air defence infrastructure ● Embassy

• Litani River Defines Battle Lines



• The Israeli Incursion Into South Lebanon



• How Trump turned off the tap

Iran was a key oil supplier to India, especially after an Obama-era sanctions waiver — until Trump rolled it back

● Oil imports from other countries ● India's total oil imports
● Oil imports from Iran (figures in million tonnes)



• Pumping up the price

The price of Brent Crude has rapidly spiked amid the war

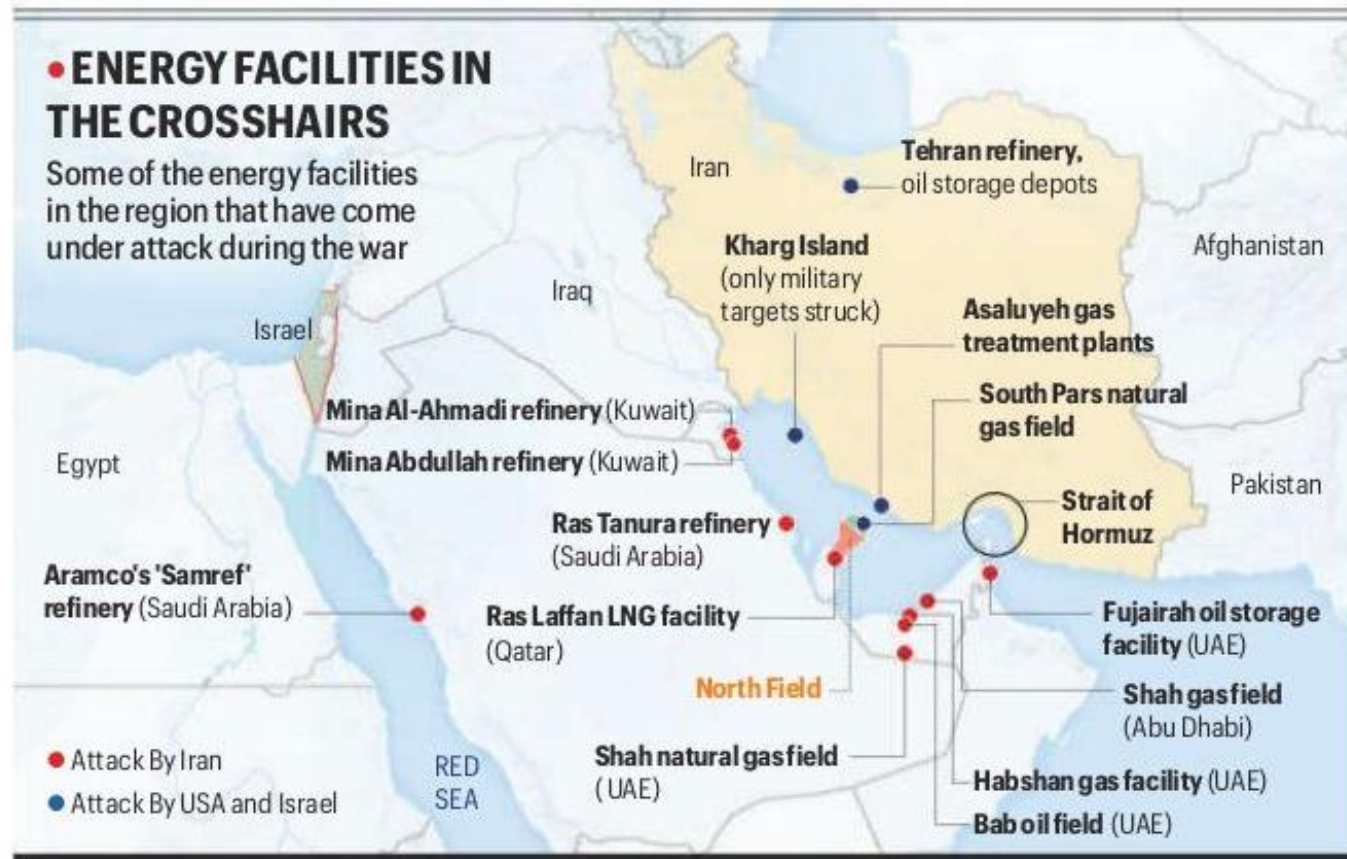


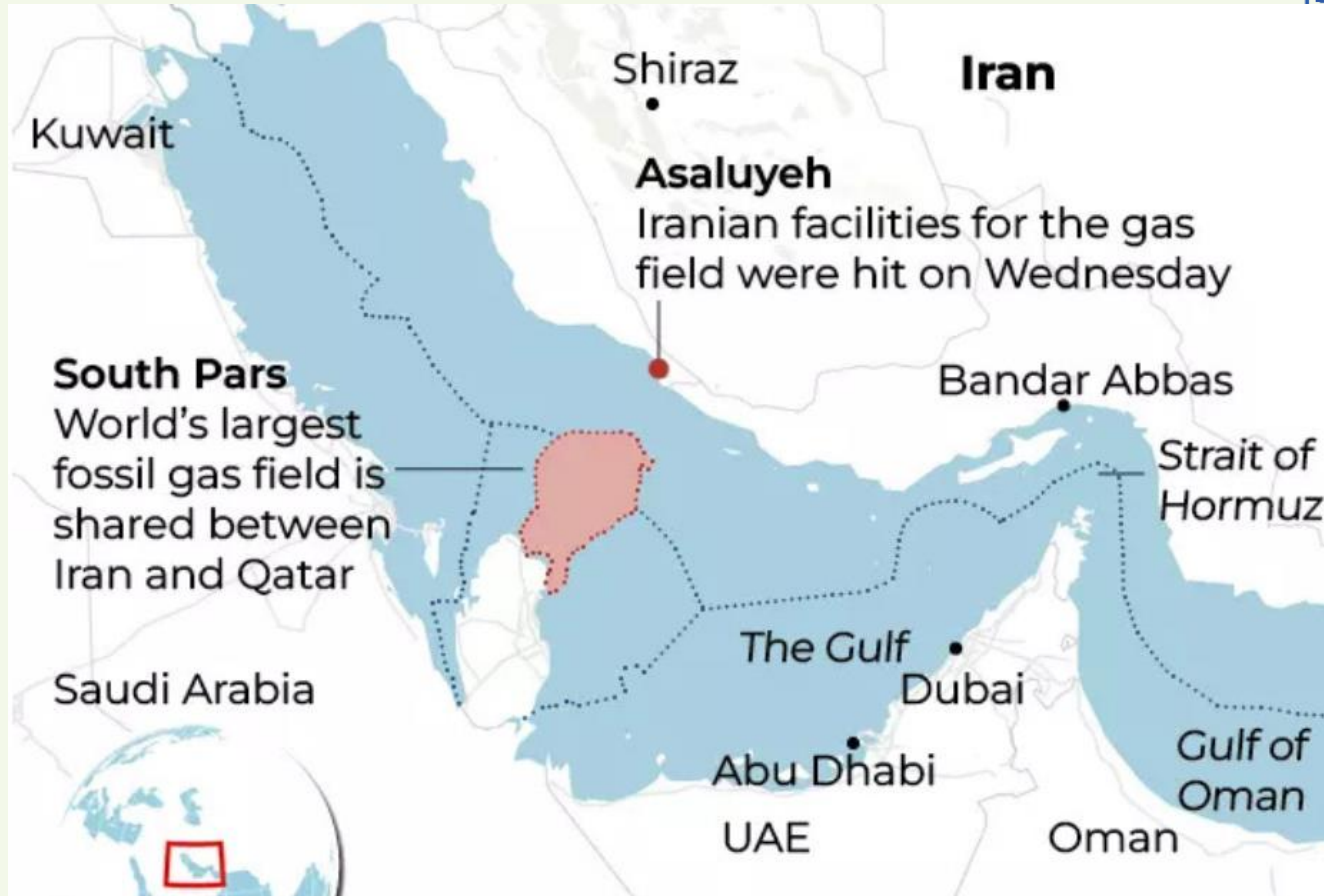
SOURCE: INVESTING.COM



• ENERGY FACILITIES IN THE CROSSHAIRS

Some of the energy facilities in the region that have come under attack during the war

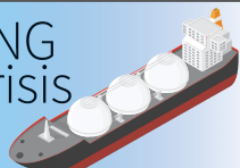




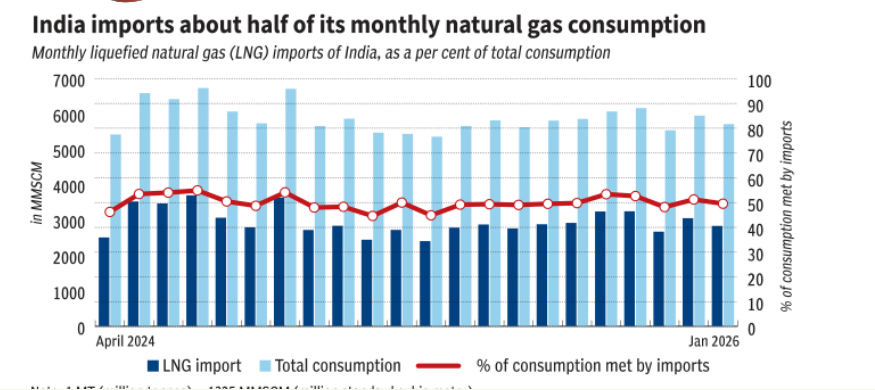
- The South Pars/North Dome field is a natural-gas condensate field located in the Persian Gulf. It is by far the world's largest natural gas field, with ownership of the field shared between Iran and Qatar.
- According to the International Energy Agency (IEA), the field holds an estimated 1,800 trillion cubic feet of in-situ natural gas and some 50 billion barrels of natural gas condensates.
- Ranked against other natural gas fields, it has almost as much recoverable reserves as all the other fields combined. It has significant geostrategic influence.



LNG crisis



The attack on the Southern Pars or North Dome gas field shared by Iran and Qatar creates multiple challenges for India. Given that about 40% of India's total LNG imports are sourced from Qatar, and India currently does not maintain a significant reserve of LNG, the disruption in supply carries the risk of crippling sectors dependent on imported LNG



At present, Qatar is the largest exporter of LNG globally, but has the third highest reserves

Major proven natural reserves	Fields	Remarks
 Russia (largest proven reserves)	Urengoy, Yamburg and Bovanenkov fields in western Siberia	Limited production and exports
 Iran (second largest proven reserves)	South Pars (shared with Qatar) is the world's single largest gas field	Limited exports
 Qatar	North Dome (Qatar's side of the South Pars field)	The single largest LNG exporter globally
 Australia	Northwest Shelf, Browse Basin, and Gorgon/Wheatstone fields	Competes with Qatar as the world's top LNG exporter
 US	Shale gas reserves in Marcellus, Haynesville, and Permian fields	Major world exporter
 Mozambique & Tanzania	Rovuma Basin	Explorations undergoing

LNG is majorly used as feedstock for fertilizers or turned into PNG and CNG

Feedstock use (molecules consumed)	Fuel uses (energy source)	City gas distribution
Fertilizers (Source of hydrogen for ammonia and urea preparation)	Ceramics and glass (Morbi tiles cluster)	Piped gas in houses (PNG)
Petrochemicals (ethylene)	Power generation (gas turbines)	Vehicles (CNG)
Refineries generating hydrogen (by steam methane reformation)	Textiles and dyeing (Surat)	
Steel (gas reduction of iron ore)	Marine heavy transport	

Source: PPAC, EIA

Crop hazard

The data for the charts were sourced from the Ministry of Trade and Commerce, the Department of Fertilizers, and the International Gas Union

Chart 1: The composition of India's LNG supply in 2025-26 (in %)

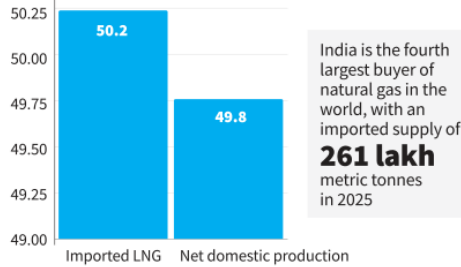


Chart 2: Country-wise share (%) of India's LNG imports in 2024-25

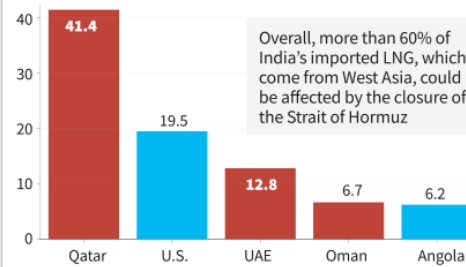


Chart 3: The distribution of LNG use in India in 2025-26 (in %)

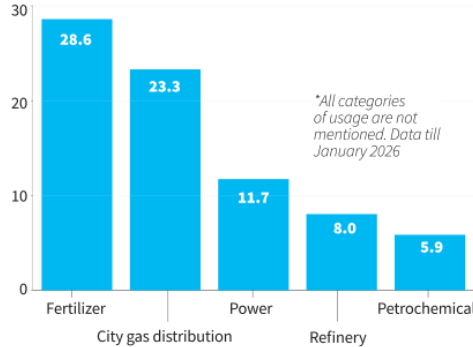
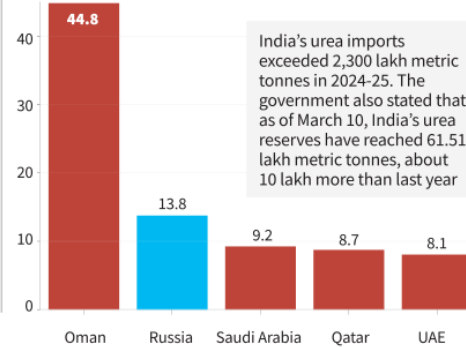


Chart 4: Country-wise share (%) of India's urea imports in 2024-25



1 Industry sources said that the country's urea plants are running at half capacity

2 Natural gas is used to produce ammonia, which in turn is used to produce fertilizers

3 LNG is the main feedstock for the production of urea, which is the most widely used fertilizer in India

4 Chart 3 and 4 only include the top 5 exporting countries

Imports of Urea

	2024-25	Apr-Dec 2025
Oman	29.56	15.27
Qatar	9.79	7.11
Russia	9.24	11.94
Saudi Arabia	5.98	5.75
UAE	5.01	4.04
Nigeria	2.83	2.67
Malaysia	1.91	3.07
Bahrain	1.34	1.2
Indonesia	1.18	6.21
China	1.04	17.05
Egypt	0.47	1.93
Georgia	0.44	1.24
Vietnam	0.08	1.86
Finland	0	3.35
Algeria	0	1.69
TOTAL*	69.1	87.24

All figures in (in lakh tonnes), *Includes other countries. Source: Department of Commerce

Imports of DAP

	2024-25	Apr-Dec 2025
Saudi Arabia	18.96	24.22
Morocco	10.26	15.9
China	8.43	5.58
Russia	2.69	6.94
Jordan	2.38	1.67
Australia	1.92	4.13
UAE	-	0.72
TOTAL*	45.6	60.08

Imports of MOP

	2024-25	Apr-Dec 2025
Russia	16.88	11.62
Canada	12.32	7.24
Turkmenistan	5.41	3.36
Jordan	3.61	1.81
Israel	3.1	1.79
UAE	0.63	0.98
TOTAL*	43.16	27.22

India's fertilizers trade dynamics

HSN code: Fertilizers	\$ (million)	Share in world imports	Rank in world Imports	Key suppliers and their export share in the world	Import dependence
Total fertilizers	7,229.2	2.9	7	—	20-25%
310530: DAP	2,800.28	28.7	1	Saudi Arabia (24%) Morocco (22%) China (27%)	40-55%
310210: Urea	2,197.59	10.8	2	Oman (15%) Russia (18%) Saudi Arabia (9.5%)	20-25%
310420: Potassium chloride	1,134.97	6.1	4	Russia (30%) Canada (37.5%)	95-100%
310520: NPK	668.13	7.7	2	Russia (32.5%)	35-45%
310230: Ammonium nitrate	167.13	5	3	Russia (36%) Georgia (4%) Bulgaria (5.6%)	15-20%
310540: Ammonium phosphate	132.12	1.7	8	China (14.3%) Russia (22.4%)	20-30%
310221: Ammonium sulphate	81.5	2	13	China (70%)	10-20%
310430: Potassium sulphate	47.48	3.8	8	Taiwan (15%)	80-90%

Source: UN Comtrade, FAI

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